producing 40–50 million tonnes on average or about 20 per cent of annual production. These two crops see varying production depending upon monsoons, floods, droughts or other climatic catastrophes.

Onion Price Gyrations

While the bulk of the onion crop is produced in Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh and Karnataka (almost two-thirds of the annual crop), the shrillest cries are heard in Delhi and other northern cities when prices shoot up. Wholesale onion prices in Delhi in the first five months (March–July) of the flush season (March–September) in the four years ending in 2019 averaged less than Rs 10 per kg, recording less than Rs 8 per kg in almost half of these months. Onion prices start rising from August (Rs 35 per kg in 2015, Rs 20 in 2017, Rs 17 in 2019) in the wholesale markets of Delhi if trouble is anticipated in the Kharif crop or the farmers decide to cut down on Kharif sowing, having received very low prices for their preceding Rabi crop. As the demand-and-supply situation gets disturbed for ensuing months (the situation gets more difficult if the late Kharif crop also suffers), prices start rising more acutely. If the Kharif turns out to be better than anticipated between September–October or there is good sowing for late Kharif, prices start reverting to their lower levels from November–December itself.

The pattern of onion prices over the years is predictable. The primary reason for the price rise from August to December is the vagaries of the weather. Traders might take advantage of the situation to make some quick money, but they are not responsible for the demand-supply gap in the months of shortages, which is entirely weather-related, sometimes accentuated by farmers receiving very low onion prices in the previous season.

Onion is not the most nutritionally rich or essential food. It contains about 90 per cent of water and some flavour. Consumers should ride through these short episodes of price volatility by paying higher prices